

BENJAMIN BLACK

Research data and software professional with a scientific background in socio-environmental systems modelling to support evidence-based policy and planning. Passionate about advancing open science, communicating research beyond academia, and mentoring others in modelling, programmatic data analysis, and visualisation. Experienced in managing small and large teams, especially in cross-cultural and interdisciplinary settings, with a strong commitment to collaborative and inclusive research.

EDUCATION

- Oct. 2020
|
Jun. 2025
- **Doctor of Civil Engineering**
ETH Zürich, chair of Planning of Landscape Urban Systems (PLUS)
📍 Zürich, Switzerland

Thesis: *Identifying effective area-based conservation strategies under uncertainties*
Awards: *Nominated for the ETH medal for outstanding doctoral theses*

Sep. 2018
|
Jun. 2020

 - **MSc in Environmental Sciences, Policy and Management (MESPOM)**
Central European University, University of Manchester, Lund University, University of the Aegean
📍 Hungary, Greece, UK

Thesis: *Assessing the ecological effectiveness of protected areas in Cambodia: a quasi-experimental counterfactual estimation of avoided deforestation*
Awards: *Outstanding academic achievement (highest GPA in cohort: 4.00/4.00)*

Sep. 2010
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Jun. 2014

 - **BSc with 1st Class Honours in Biological Sciences**
Edinburgh Napier University
📍 Edinburgh, Scotland

Thesis: *Simulating the future potential of degraded Mangrove plots using field data from Kenya*
Awards: *University medal (highest average mark on degree route); Lawrence Ho student prize; Dennis Aw award.*

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

- February.
2026
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Present
- **Head of the Working Group Data and Modelling Infrastructure for Living Labs**
Leibniz-Zentrum für Agrarlandschaftsforschung (ZALF)
📍 Müncheberg, Germany

Lead the development of data and modelling infrastructure for the Living Labs within the Innovation Centre for Agricultural Transformation (IAT).
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- October.
2025
|
January.
2026
- **Postdoctoral Researcher**
ETH Zürich
📍 Zürich, Switzerland

Lead the research of two funded projects on landscape change in Switzerland and Peru.
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- May. 2025
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Jul. 2025
- **Freelance Research Consultant**
Prognos AG
📍 Zürich, Switzerland

Performed Land Use and Land Cover change modelling of Shared Socioeconomic Pathways for Switzerland as part of project funded by the Swiss National Centre for Climate Services
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- Jul. 2019
|
Aug. 2019
- **Biodiversity and SMART Intern**
The Wildlife Conservation Society (WCS)
📍 Phnom Penh, Cambodia

Developed a programmatic routine to expedite the collection of external data from the IUCN, EDGE ranking and CITES to produce protected area species inventories in line with Darwin Core standards. Assisted in the training of new community biodiversity rangers in the process of SMART data collection in the field.



CONTACT INFO

👤 Head of the Service Working Group
Data and Modelling Infrastructure for
Living Labs

🏛️ Leibniz Centre for Agricultural
Landscape Research (ZALF)

🏠 Müncheberg, Germany



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📄 <https://www.researchgate.net/profile/Benjamin-Black-5>

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Advanced: R (Shiny, Quarto),
Dinamica EGO, Netica and MS
Office

Intermediate: ArcGIS, QGIS, CSS
and Git

Basic: Python, HTML, Docker,
JavaScript, Bash and Slurm

LANGUAGES

English: Native

German: B2

Jan. 2018
|
Aug. 2018

Student Affairs Manager

The School for Field Studies Center for Conservation and Development Studies in the Lower Mekong

📍 Siem Reap, Cambodia

Coordinated safety and risk management as well as logistics for all centre activities including multi day field trips to remote locations. Served as the medical point person, facilitating first aid training for staff, while also supporting student well-being and cultural adaptation in a pastoral role.

April. 2015
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June. 2017

Project Manager & Volunteer Co-ordinator

Elephant Livelihood Initiatives and Environment (E.L.I.E)

📍 Mondulhiri, Cambodia

Managed a diverse team (Bunong Indigenous minority, and Khmer) of 48 staff. Oversaw the operation of an ecotourism project receiving 4000+ visitors a year. Facilitated ongoing capacity building of staff and development of the volunteer program. Compiled budgets, managed cash flow, and created detailed financial and organizational reports.



TEACHING, TRAINING & WORKSHOP DELIVERY

Sep. 2024

Reproducible Research with R and Quarto: Workflows for data, projects and publications

Three hour workshop as part of Landscape 2024 conference

📍 Berlin, Germany

 Website

Feb. 2021
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Jul. 2024

Participatory Environmental Modelling: MSc course at ETH Zürich

Designed and taught an MSc-level course integrating students and practitioners to develop simulation models for real-world environmental decision-making.

📍 Zürich, Switzerland



GRANTS & FUNDING

Dec. 2024

Future development of biodiversity and ecosystem services as a basis for the revision of the sectoral plan for biodiversity

Canton of Bern Department of Agriculture and Nature

📍 Bern, Switzerland

Project in collaboration with the Wyss Academy for Nature to generate policy-relevant evidence supporting the canton's revision of the sectoral biodiversity plan.

 Website

Jun. 2023

Nature-positive Scenarios for Environmental Transitions Peru (NASCENT-PERU)

Swiss Re Foundation

📍 Zürich, Switzerland

Funded project under the SwissRE Biodiversity and Ecosystem Services Scenarios Modelling Initiative

 Website



PUBLICATIONS

- 2026 ● **The PAVE pathway: how to talk about models with people who did(n't) build them**
Bell, A., Troost, C., Filatova, T., Vincenot, C., Qin, C., Fiedler, S., Lemmen, C., Lynch, I., Pierce, M., Edmonds, B., McIntire, E., Wang, H., Koralewski, T., Grant, W., Wang, M., [Black, B.](#), Grimm, V.
Bioscience  Read
- 2025 ● **Where will the change come from? Identifying decision-relevant factors in future Land Use and Cover Change ({LUCC}) scenarios to support planning under uncertainty**
Roman, O., Adey, B., [Black, B.](#) and Zeindl, E.
Futures  Read
- In Review ● **Temporal Archetypes of Nature's Contributions to People for Sustainable Landscape Development**
Wicki, S., [Black, B.](#), Külling, N., Kurmann, M., Wang, J., Lehmann, A., Gret-Regamey, A.
Regional Environmental Change
- 2026 ● **Identifying robust area-based conservation strategies to secure ecosystem service provision under uncertainties**
[Black, B.](#) and Adde, A. and Külling, N. and Büth, C. and Kurmann, M. and Lehmann, A. and Altermatt, F. and Guisan, A. and Gret-Regamey, A.
Journal of Environmental Management  Read  Code
- 2024 ● **Broadening the horizon in land use change modelling: Normative scenarios for nature positive futures in Switzerland**
[Black, B.](#) and Adde, A. and Farinotti, D. and Guisan, A. and Külling, N. and Kurmann, M. and Martin, C. and Mayer, P. and Rabe, S and Streit, J. and Zekollari, H. and Grêt-Regamey, A.
Regional Environmental Change  Read  Data  Code
- 2023 ● **Archetypes of social-ecological-technological systems for managing ecological infrastructure**
Wicki, S. and [Black, B.](#) and Kurmann, M. and Grêt-Regamey, A.
Environmental Research Letters  Read
- 2023 ● **Re-considering the status quo: Improving calibration of land use change models through validation of transition potential predictions**
[Black, B.](#) and van Strien, M. J. and Adde, A. and Grêt-Regamey, A.
Environmental Modelling & Software  Read  Code
- 2022 ● **Counterfactual assessment of protected area avoided deforestation in Cambodia: Trends in effectiveness, spillover effects and the influence of establishment date**
[Black, B.](#) and Anthony, B. P.
Global Ecology and Conservation  Read  Data



PRESENTATIONS

- Jun. 2025 ● **A “Scope, Simulation and Story” approach to identify future spatial development scenarios**
Computational Urban Planning and Urban Management Conference 2025
 University College London  Slides
- Sep. 2024 ● **Negotiating scenarios of a desirable ecological infrastructure for Switzerland**
4th Swiss Landscape Congress  Tramelan, Switzerland  Slides

- Jun. 2024 ● **Normative scenarios of landscape change for Nature-Positive futures in Peru**
World Biodiversity Forum  Davos, Switzerland
- Nov. 2023 ● **Exploratory modelling of stochastic land use cover change (LUCC) future scenarios for spatial planning**
10th Annual Conference of the Society for Decision Making Under Deep Uncertainty (DMDU 2023)  Delft, Netherlands
- Nov. 2023 ● **Broadening the scope of future visions for nature positive futures in Peru**
Swiss Re Institute Resilience Summit 2023  Zürich, Switzerland

 Slides

 Slides